



YOU'RE WONDERFUL, IN A LOATHSOME SORT OF WAY

HIS GIRL FRIDAY / 1940

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Screwball comedy

DIRECTOR

Howard Hawks

WRITERS

Charles Lederer (screenplay); Ben Hecht, Charles MacArthur (play)

STARS

Cary Grant, Rosalind Russell

BEFORE

1931 The first movie version of the stage play *The Front Page* is directed by Lewis Milestone, and stars Adolphe Menjou and Pat O'Brien.

AFTER

1941 Grant and Russell reprise their roles for a radio version of the movie, broadcast by The Screen Guild Theater.

1974 Billy Wilder directs a remake of *The Front Page*, starring Jack Lemmon and Walter Matthau.

Howard Hawks's sharply scripted screwball comedy about the daily newspaper world is one of the smartest movies of the black-and-white era. Famous for its overlapping, machine-gun-fast dialogue, it portrays journalists who will stoop to anything in their hunt for a good story. The movie's press hotshot leads lie, cheat, and connive, yet they win the viewer over with their charm, energy, and brilliant comic timing.

Play adaptation

His Girl Friday was based on a 1928 play about the corrupt world of the press, *The Front Page*, of which a movie version had already been made. In *The Front Page*, the battle of wits is between two newspapermen, but Hawks made a key change. After reading scenes from the play with his girlfriend, Hawks is said to

Walter (Cary Grant) schemes to prevent his ex-wife Hildy (Rosalind Russell) from marrying another by reminding her how much she loves her job.

have exclaimed, "Hey, it's even better with a woman and a man than with two men." And so, in Charles Lederer's screenplay, the two newspapermen become a recently divorced couple: hard-boiled editor Walter Burns

